# Proposal Seeking $25,000 for a Land Conservation Assistance Grant to Formulate an Open Space and Recreation Plan for the High Road.

Submitted on Behalf of Berkshire Natural Resources Council.
By Marlie Fitch,
29 November 2025.

Darya Mattes,
Resilient Lands Open Space Grants Administrator
Division of Conservation Services
Executive Office of Energy and Environmental Affairs
100 Cambridge Street, Suite 900
Boston, MA 02114

29 November 2025

Dear Ms. Mattes,

I am pleased to submit the Massachusetts Executive Office of Energy and Environmental Affairs application for the Land Conservation Assistance Grant for FY26 on behalf of Berkshire Natural Resources Council (BNRC). We are requesting $25,000 for assistance in constructing an Open Space and Recreation Plan for the 6-mile expansion of the High Road, covering the Northern and Southernmost areas of Stockbridge, MA. The High Road is Berkshire County's first free town-to-town trail system, with a mission of promoting outdoor recreational activity and mitigating the damaging effects of climate change in Berkshire County through transforming conserved parcels of land into accessible trails.

The Open Space and Recreation Plan will be a 100+ page document serving as the first steps in the expansion of the High Road. The completion of the plan will provide a solid layout of our goals, featuring governmental and non-governmental partnerships, land assessments, and recreational community needs. These factors are necessary in order to gain eligibility for state grants to fund the physical expansion and maintenance of the High Road. We are dedicating five months and three full-time employees to the Open Space and Recreation Plan. The requested amount of $25,000 will go toward partnering with Berkshire Regional Planning Commission (BRPC) and the Massachusetts Department of Conservation and Recreation (Mass DCR) who will be responsible for collecting data necessary for the project.

BNRC, based in Lenox, MA, is a 501 (c)(3) organization that has conserved more than 27,000 acres of land since its founding in 1967. Our mission is to conserve land in Berkshire County and transform it into free, public spaces where community members can engage with nature. In a world growing dependent on technology, we value the integration of nature and urbanism. Our mission is to provide ecological and climate awareness in Berkshire County by offering free guided classes and hikes on our trails.

We appreciate your consideration and are eager to collaborate with you in the future. For any additional information about our project or proposal, please contact mjfitch@umass.edu.

Sincerely,

Marlie Fitch

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# 1. Statement of Problem

Berkshire County, the second largest county in Massachusetts by land, is home to the Yokun Ridge, Mount Greylock, parts of the Appalachian Trail, and thousands of acres of natural land. In 2020, 86.9% of tourists engaged in outdoor recreational activities, such as hiking on trails, viewing fall foliage, and skiing at mountain resorts ("Berkshire Regional..."). With 78% of the county consisting of forested land, Berkshire County's identity is rooted in nature. However, the ecosystem and economy of Berkshire County is under threat by the effects of climate change. Michael Rawlins, associate director of the University of Massachusetts Amherst's Climate System Research Center, observed an increase in extreme weather events, where the county is expected to see, "More very warm days and more days with extreme precipitation (Carol)." The environment of Berkshire County is under threat due to climate change and needs to be protected in order to preserve the area's natural beauty and native species.

Figure 1. The Mahanna Cobble Reserve Trailhead: the first segment of the High Road, located in Pittsfield, MA. Image courtesy of BNRC https://www.bnrc.org/story/bnrc-opens-new-mahanna-cobble-trail.

## A. Air Particle Pollution

In the summers of 2024 and 2025, Berkshire County citizens experienced health risks and environmental challenges due to prolonged periods of poor air quality caused by wildfire smoke flowing into the region. Hazy skies covered the county as citizens were alerted by state officials to stay indoors. The warnings lasted a week, preventing many citizens from enjoying outdoor recreation. The summers of 2024 and 2025 were a sign that air particle pollution had reached its peak, yet it was not an introduction to the problem, but rather, a reminder. According to the American Lung Association, Berkshire County's annual average number of days with a hazardous level of air particle pollutants between 2021-2023 was 3.2 days, a sharp increase from 2016-2020 where the average was 0.3 days per year (American Lung Association). Berkshire County has a history of air particle pollution, and the consequences will only get worse if no preventive measures are taken.

According to a 2020 study conducted by Berkshire Regional Action Team, there is a direct correlation between air particle pollution and the average life span for Berkshire County citizens based on which area they live in. Those living in low-income areas of Pittsfield, such as the Central and Morningside neighborhoods, have a lifespan average of 72.5 years, 10-12 years less than those living in high-income areas ("Breathe Easy..."). Pittsfield's low-income areas are heavily industrialized, with a higher volume of traffic, stores, and car dealerships, as opposed to medium-to-high income areas which consist of more forested land. The industrialized areas contribute to the combustion of fossil fuels, thus aiding in Pittsfield's overall increase in air particle pollution.

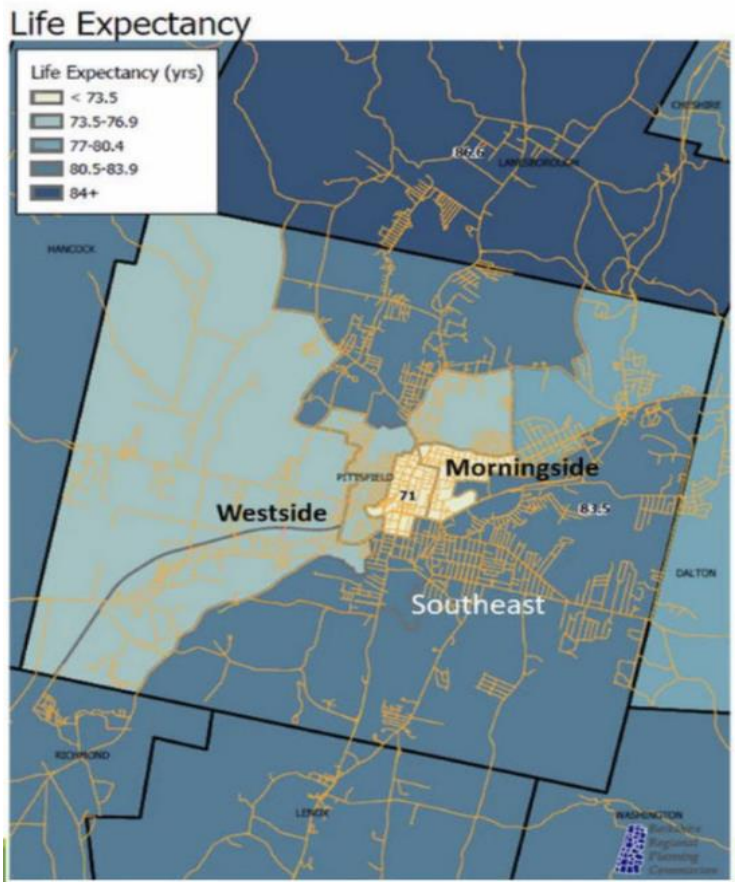


Figure 2. Map of Berkshire County displaying average life expectancy per neighborhood based on air quality levels. Image courtesy of Breathe Easy Berkshires, breatheeasyberkshires.org/our-mission.

Furthermore, at the center of the low-income areas is Silver Lake: a lake with a history of chemical contamination. In the mid-to-late 1950's, the lake was used by General Electric as a polychlorinated biphenyl (PCB) dumping ground for their factory. While lake cleanup efforts have reigned in decent success, chemicals leaking into the environment from General Electric are still prevalent. The chemicals, while originally sourced in bodies of water, can spread into the air through moisture and evaporation.

Air particle pollution can introduce drastic health complications, even to those who are exposed for only a small amount of time. Fine particle matter, a type of wildfire pollutant, can enter an

individual's lungs and bloodstream, causing cancer, asthma, and cardiovascular disease (Becker). While those most at risk are children, the elderly, pregnant women, and individuals with underlying health complications, everyone, regardless of their age, gender, or health record, can fall victim to illnesses or death.

## B. Rise in Temperatures

Globally, New England exhibits one of the highest rates of temperature increases. Between 1990-2020, the average annual temperature in New England increased to more than 34°F (Young). As a result, the rise in temperatures can cause health complications such as heat stroke and death, yet the issues are not exclusive to humans. Hotter temperatures can damage infrastructures, contribute to severe droughts, and impact the behavioral patterns of wildlife and plants (European Commission).

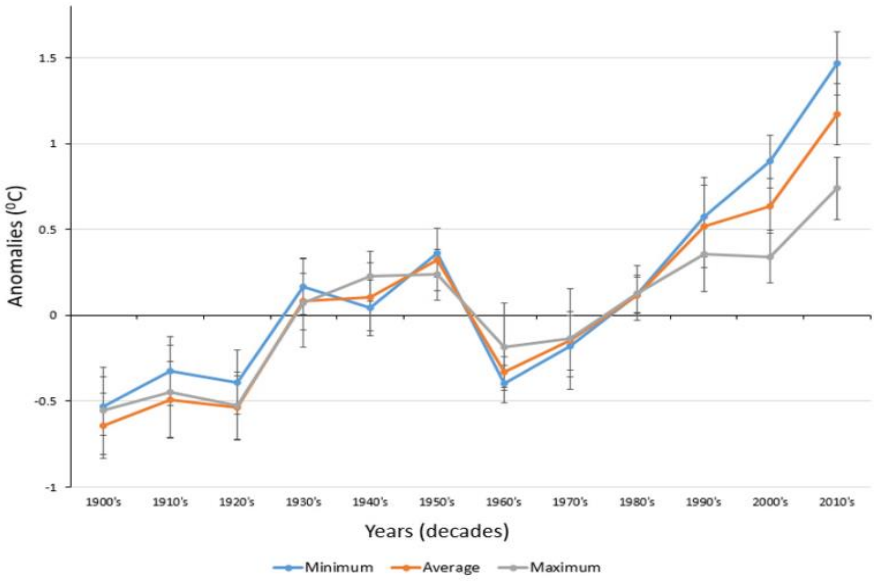


Figure 3. Graph representing a rise in decadal temperature anomalies for New England between 1900-2010. Image courtesy of Stephen S. Young, https://www.mdpi.com/2225-1154/9/12/176

One direct environmental impact from rising temperatures is an increase in tick-borne related illnesses. Warm weather acts as a breeding ground for ticks, providing the invasive species with a longer season to reproduce. In Berkshire County, citizens have fallen victim to tick-related illnesses at an exponential rate. In 2025, Berkshire County had one of Massachusetts's highest Lyme disease incidence rates, with an average of 17.1 recorded hospital cases per 10,000 people ("Monthly Tick-borne...”). Ticks can cause harm to humans, as well as domestic pets and wild species.

Apart from ticks, another environmental aspect facing the consequences of temperature rises are Berkshire County farms. Hotter weather can diminish agricultural yields by drying up plants and soil, as well as disrupting photosynthesis which can prevent growth (Proctor). Similarly, hotter weather can cause heat stress for livestock. For example, cows under heat stress produce less milk. Expensive resources, such as cooling systems, are needed to regulate cows’ body temperatures, which some farmers cannot afford. Farmers across Berkshire County have seen a significant decrease in their annual yields, with many agreeing that the days of “Old-time farming are gone” (Bilder). Berkshire County is home to over 400 farms, with a market value of $36 million, and is responsible for 6% of Massachusetts's total agricultural sales (“Percent of State...”). A rise in temperatures creates an equal risk between the environment and the economy.

Furthermore, farming is not the only industry at risk due to temperature increases. Berkshire County’s skiing industry is one of the county’s highest sources of revenue, and is dependent on cool temperatures to operate. Ski resorts such as Bosquet Mountain and Jiminy Peak contribute more than $50 million to Berkshire County’s economy, with more than 250,000 individuals

visiting Jiminy Peak annually (Stafford). With higher temperatures, the winter season could become much shorter, causing skiing tourists to either visit for less time, or skip Berkshire County entirely. The repercussions caused by a lack of tourists extend past ski resorts, as a decline in tourism can cause the over 2,000 local businesses that rely on seasonal tourists to go bankrupt.

## C. Flooding

Temperature rises in Berkshire County have also been a source of hazardous weather conditions, most notably: flooding. Moisture absorbed into the atmosphere during hot summers can lead to severe rainfall. Over the last 80 years, Berkshire County has seen a more than 5% increase in precipitation ("Berkshire County Hazard..."). Rain, under normal conditions, typically falls in even distributions throughout the week, yet hotter temperatures cause rain to pour all at once, creating flooding conditions throughout the county.

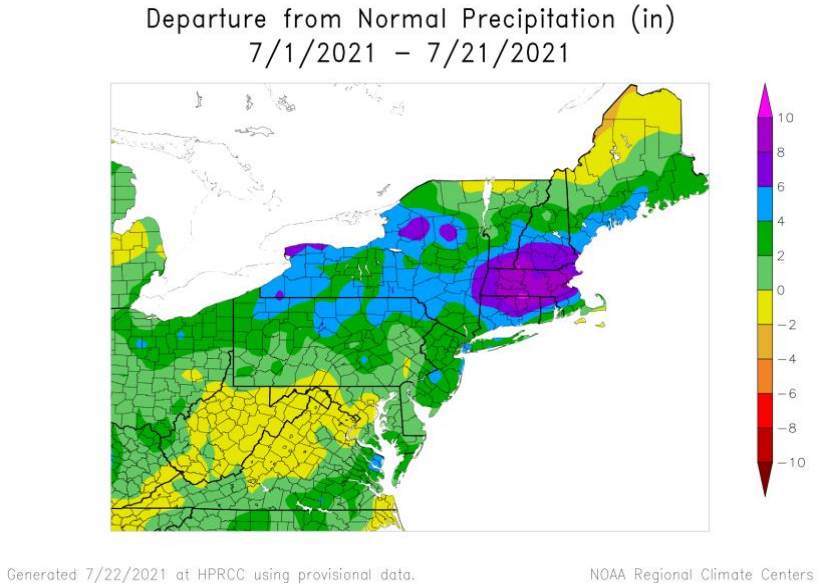


Figure 4. Map displaying rain abnormality rates across the Northeast of the U.S. Image courtesy of the National Weather Service, https://www.weather.gov/car/July2021ClimateReview.

In 2021, researchers at the University of Massachusetts Amherst assessed that Berkshire County is in an unsafe condition based on its underdeveloped floodplains and dams ("UMass Study Outlines..."). Much of the infrastructure in Berkshire County is dated and does not meet Massachusetts's state guidelines for historical buildings. An estimate of 20% of Berkshire County properties, including private homes and public spaces, are at a severe risk of flood damage over the next 30 years ("Berkshire County, MA. Flood..."). Properties are not the only form of infrastructure at risk, as intense flooding can cause permanent damage to power stations and roads. Berkshire County's future flooding trends will bring irreversible damage to citizens and infrastructure if preventative measures are not implemented.

## 2. Statement of Request

On behalf of Berkshire Natural Resources Council (BNRC), the purpose of this proposal is to request funding for the development of an Open Space and Recreation Plan for the High Road's 2026-2027 expansion from the southernmost point of Northern Stockbridge to Stockbridge's Main Street. In order for the project to come to fruition, BNRC would like to request a grant amount of $25,000 from the Executive Office of Energy & Environmental Affairs, on the grounds of the Open Space and Recreation Plan being a mandatory first step in the 6-mile expansion of the High Road. The plan will allow us to gain governmental funding and permission to prepare parcels of land for conservation, which will then allow us to develop the next segment of the High Road.

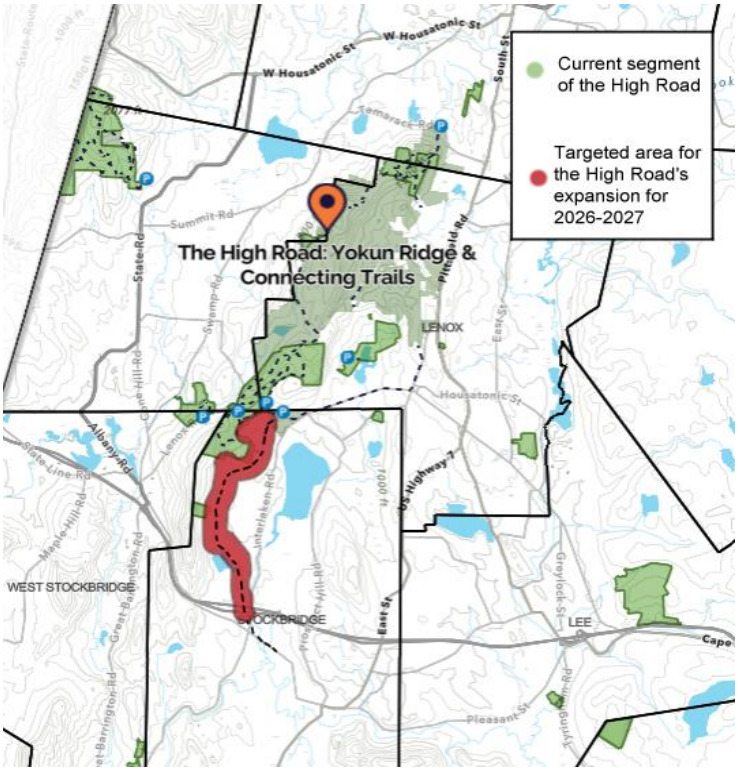


Figure 5: Current map of the High Road. Green areas represent areas owned by BNRC. Red areas represent targeted areas of land for the High Road's expansion. Map courtesy of BNRC, edited by Marlie Fitch, https://www.bnrc.org/reserves/the-high-road-yokun-ridge-connecting-trails.

Founded in 2021, the High Road is a long-term, major conservation initiative. Unlike other trail systems in the region, the High Road aims to become Berkshire County's first free town-to-town trail system, linking forested and urban areas together. The trails are designed to go in-and-out of Berkshire County municipalities, granting tourists and citizens the opportunity to explore wildlife and local businesses. With the requested amount of $25,000, BNRC will use the High Road to achieve land conservation for the sake of protecting natural wildlife, promoting outdoor recreational activities, providing support to small business, and as a local initiative of mitigating the effects climate change poses to Berkshire County.

## 3. Conservation Benefits

Land conservation is directly correlated to mitigate problems produced by climate change on a local and regional level. While it would take hundreds of years of fossil fuel reduction to reverse damage caused by global carbon emissions, land conservation plays a critical role in lessening the effects through carbon absorption, air purification, and temperature regulation. Land conservation won't end global climate change; it will instead act as a local initiative that protects natural wildlife while lessening the damage caused by climate change.

Due to conservation efforts across Berkshire County, the region already surpassed 25% of Massachusetts's 2020 emission reduction goals (Schottland et al.). Berkshire County is at the forefront of climate change mitigation, and much of that is thanks to its thousands of acres of conserved land. Continuing to protect every aspect of the environment through land conservation is crucial for the fight against climate change, and the High Road will prevent Berkshire County's current problems from increasing.

### A. Air Particle Pollution Prevention

Land conservation is a direct way to combat health complications that arise from air particle pollution. Trees function as a natural air filter by absorbing carbon dioxide and toxic pollutants onto the surface of leaves. As of 2010, trees across the U.S. removed 17.4 million tons of air pollution from the atmosphere, preventing 670,000 cases of respiratory illnesses (Nisley). While forests are a crucial part of air purification, Berkshire County still faces prevalent air particle pollution issues, despite 78% of the region consisting of forested land. Ensuring that Berkshire

County's forested land stays plentiful and protected from deforestation is necessary in order to prevent air quality from further decreasing.

## B. Temperature Regulation

Berkshire County forests already play a significant role in purifying the air, yet they can also regulate outdoor temperatures by keeping the environment cool. Trees, plants, and bodies of water can regulate outdoor temperatures by absorbing heat radiating from sunlight. A study done by William Moomaw, a former researcher for the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, discovered that Berkshire County is 6-8°F cooler in the summer due to forests providing shade, cleaning the air, and purifying water (Jin). Already, Berkshire County forests are regulating temperatures which prevent the county from overheating. Preserving forests is crucial in order to prevent the risks that increased temperatures pose onto the environment, livestock, and people.

## C. Flood Maintenance

Forests also prevent hazardous flooding conditions, which in turn, saves communities and ecosystems from the consequences of intense flooding. Trees can reduce the speed and impact of intense wind and storms by acting as a cushion to extreme rainfall, as well as absorb gallons of water produced by storms. Additionally, a tree's roots prevent erosion and landslides caused by severe storms by acting as an anchor in the ground.

Figure 6. Basin Pond, a BNRC conserved wetland in Lee, MA. Image courtesy of Berkshires Outside, https://berkshiresoutside.org/place/basin-pond-lee-ma/.

Apart from forests, wetlands also reduce flooding in similar ways. Wetlands function as a natural sponge that absorbs massive amounts of stormwater and slowly releases it over time. 9% of Berkshire County's natural land consists of wetlands ("Berkshire County Hazard..."), which are vulnerable to climate change due to being at risk of drying out from droughts. Confronting the issues posed by climate change while damage is reversible will ensure ecosystems are not permanently damaged.

## 4. Description of Proposed Work

The long-term goal of the High Road is for the trail to stretch from Williamstown to Sheffield– the northern and southernmost points of Berkshire County. The completed version will take more than 15 years of land conservation, trail development, maintenance, and additional funding. Our focus for 2026-2027 is to concentrate on the High Road's 6-mile expansion. Currently, the High Road is 10-miles long, beginning at Bousquet Mountain, located in Pittsfield, to Kripalu Center

for Yoga & Health, located in Stockbridge. The expansion will focus on continuing the High Road into Stockbridge's Main Street.

The requested amount of $25,000 will go toward the five-month long construction of an Open Space and Recreation plan–a necessary, legal step that will allow us to request governmental funding for the High Road's expansion. The Open Space and Recreation plan will be a 100+ page document that reflects community needs of land management, protection, conservation, and recreation. The requested amount of $25,000 will also allow us to partner with Berkshire Regional Planning Commission (BRPC), a nongovernmental organization that specializes in assisting in Open Space and Recreation Plans across Western Massachusetts through data collection and analysis. Additionally, the funding will also allow us to partner with the Massachusetts Department of Conservation and Recreation (Mass DCR), who will construct an environmental inventory.

## A. Project Objectives

- Partner with the Town of Stockbridge
    - Working with the Town of Stockbridge is a mandatory step due to our focus on expanding the High Road into the town. Currently, the Town of Stockbridge owns the parcels of land we are seeking to conserve. By preparing a contractual partnership with the Town of Stockbridge, we will be able to conserve our targeted parcels of land and transform them into parts of the High Road once the Open Space and Recreation Plan is completed.
- Collect Data and Enact Land Surveys

- BRPC and Mass DCR will be responsible for collecting a variety of data in order to ensure the Open Space and Recreation Plan consists of updated, accurate information. Over the course of five months, they will gather:
    - Community & demographic data
        - Recreational needs assessment of Berkshire County
        - Population characteristics
        - Project growth patterns and outlook
    - Topographic survey
        - Map production
    - Environmental inventory
        - Land survey
        - Climate resilience
        - Native species

- Construct an Open Space and Recreation Plan
    - Once BRPC and Mass DCR collect all the needed data, we will be able to format the written document and prepare it for state approval. The plan will consist of, but is not limited to:
        - Plan summary
        - Community setting
        - Environmental inventory and analysis
        - Ownership & protection status
        - Trail map
        - Recreational interest

    - Community goals
    - Analysis of needs
    - Goals and objectives
    - Action plan
- Submission for state approval
    - The Open Space and Recreation plan's last step is to gain approval from the Commonwealth of Massachusetts. Once approved, we can use the plan to allow us to legally conserve land, and to gain state funding for the High Road's expansion.

## 5. Timeline

The construction of the Open Space and Recreation Plan for the High Road will take approximately five months total. The process will be broken into three stages: communicating with the Town of Stockbridge to prepare a partnership for land conservation; collecting data; and drafting the written document. Most of the time will be spent coordinating with BRPC and Mass DCR, who will be responsible for gathering data. After all the required data has been collected, we will begin drafting the Open Space and Recreation Plan over the course of a month. We will continue to collaborate with BRPC and Mass DCR during this stage to ensure the included data is accurate. When the Open Space and Recreation Plan is complete, we will submit it to the Commonwealth of Massachusetts to gain legal approval over the plan.

| **Action** | **Timeframe** |
|---|---|

| | |
|---|---|
| Discuss a partnership with the Town of Stockbridge in preparation for the High Road's expansion (Performed by BNRC) | January 12th-January 23rd |
| Topographic survey & map production (Conducted by BRPC) | January 26th–February 20th |
| Environmental site assessment & inventory (Conducted by Mass DCR) | February 18th–March 16th |
| Community & demographic data (Conducted by BRPC) | February 23rd–April 10th |
| Brief the Town of Stockbridge on collected data and project progress (Conducted by BNRC) | April 13th |
| Drafting of the written document (Conducted by | April 15th–May 12th |

| | |
|---|---|
| BNRC) | |
| Submission of the Open Space and Recreation Plan for state approval (Performed by BNRC) | May 13th |

## 6. Measurement & Confidence of Project Success

We will measure the rate of success for the Open Space and Recreation Plan for the High Road in accordance with its completion and state approval, as well as the acquisition of a partnership with the Town of Stockbridge.

Between 2021-2024, the High Road's current segment has seen high engagement between Berkshire County citizens and tourists. Based on the community's positive reception toward the High Road's first stages, we are confident visitors will enjoy the 6-mile expansion. The High Road's past accomplishments will serve as a template for its expansion.

Figure 7. Hikers on the High Road in 2021. Image courtesy of BNRC, https://www.bnrc.org/.

# 7. Available Facilities

BNRC's headquarters is located at 309 Pittsfield Rd., Ste B Lenox, MA 01240. There is enough space provided in the facility to support each of our eighteen personnel, despite three employees being responsible for the Open Space and Recreation Plan. Additionally, each employee has access to software programs and virtual browsers to assist in the development of the plan.

Our focus on expanding the High Road into Stockbridge's Main Street is because the town is home to a variety of historical and modern tourist spots. Such spots are the Red Lion Inn, the Norman Rockwell Museum, Berkshire Botanical Garden, Naumkeag, and the National Shrine of the Divine Mercy. The city is also home to several locally owned restaurants, cafes, and stores, with the majority being located in the town's center. Businesses in Stockbridge are already accustomed to a high volume of tourists, and the High Road will continue to provide additional financial gain for the town and business owners.

Figure 8. People gathered on Main Street, Stockbridge, MA. Image courtesy of Boston.com, https://www.boston.com/travel/new-england-travel/2024/12/06/today-show-charming-magical-main-street-in-stockbridge/

# 8. Qualifications of Personnel, Partners, & Responsibilities

BNRC is a tax-exempt non-profit organization under Section 501 (c)(3) of the Internal Revenue Code. Since its founding in 1967, BNRC has conserved over 27,000 acres of land across Berkshire County through collaborating with governmental and non-governmental organizations, and private landowners. In 2023, BNRC earned accreditation by the National Land Trust Accreditation Commission, a title which only 10% of Massachusetts land trusts possess.

BNRC has eighteen full-time employees and receives seasonal help via volunteers who aid in trail management. For the Open Space and Recreation Plan, BNRC will entrust the construction of the document to three employees who will be managed by our president. Each employee will be responsible for a different aspect of the plan, yet will collaborate throughout the process.

- BNRC's Director of Stewardship, Doug Brown, will be responsible for communicating and working closely alongside BRPC and Mass DCR to obtain and analyze data for the Open Space and Recreation Plan. He has a Master's Degree in Environmental Studies from Antioch University of New England. Additionally, he has experience as a land steward at the Upper Valley Land Trust and as a Public Lands Manager at the Columbia Land Conservancy.
- BNRC's Grants Specialist, Amy Dryansky, will draft and revise the Open Space and Recreation Plan and work closely with other personnel to ensure data is accurately represented in the written plan. She has a Master's Degree in Poetry from Vermont College of Fine Arts, and experience as an administrator and communications professional.
- BNRC's Land Conservation Projects Manager, Cosmo LaViola, will be responsible for communicating and working closely with government officials representing the Town of Stockbridge to prepare the legal processes of conserving parcels of land owned by the town. He has a Master's Degree in STEM Education and Forest Resources and Arboriculture from the University of Massachusetts Amherst. He held positions at Mass Audubon and the Department of Conservation and Recreation before joining BNRC.
- BNRC's president, Jenny Hansell, will oversee and manage the development of the Open Space and Recreation Plan, as well as communicate with donors and Berkshire County about our plans for the High Road's expansion. She has a Master's Degree in Public Administration from the University of Connecticut. During her seven years as President, she has helped triple the size of the staff and budget, as well as enable the conservation of over 6,000 acres of land and development of the High Road.

Additionally, we will be working closely with BRPC and Mass DCR, who will be responsible for data collection and land assessment. Both organizations have performed extensive data collection for the first segment of the High Road in 2021, as well as helped organizations across Western Massachusetts prepare Open Space and Outdoor Recreation plans. We are confident that BRPC and Mass DCR will provide a thorough data collection and analysis based on their past accomplishments.

## 9. Budget

The majority of the $25,000 we are requesting will go toward hiring BRPC and Mass DCR for data collection and analysis. Following the grant guidelines, staff budgeting will not be covered through funding received by this grant. However, we have secured enough additional funding through other grant programs and donations to ensure BNRC maintains operation extending past this project.

| **Expense** | **Amount Needed** |
|---|---|
| State title examination | $1,000 |
| Hiring BRPC to conduct a topographic survey & produce a map | $6,000 |
| Hiring Mass DCR to conduct an environmental site assessment & inventory | $6,000 |
| Hiring BRPC to conduct a community survey | $12,000 |

| | |
|---|---|
| & gather demographic data | |
| **Total:** | $25,000 |

Expenses were calculated based on an estimate given by BRPC and Mass DCR. The topographic survey and map production, along with the environmental site assessment and inventory, are projected to take a month in total for completion, with each averaging at a total cost of $6,000. The community survey and demographic data collection are estimated to take two months at twice the rate, totaling $12,000.

## 10. Summary

The Open Space and Recreation Plan is a mandatory step to allow BNRC to expand the High Road. The goal of the High Road is to provide a free, accessible trail system formed out of parcels of conserved land across Berkshire County in order to mitigate climate change-related issues while simultaneously working to promote outdoor recreational activity and help small businesses through tourism. Our previous efforts and partnerships have already led to the successful opening of the first 10-mile segment of the High Road in 2021. Our next objective for 2026-2027 is to expand the High Road 6-miles into Southern Stockbridge. Through the Massachusetts Executive Office of Energy and Environmental Affairs' Land Conservation Assistance Grant, BNRC will ensure Berkshire County becomes the prime example of outdoor recreational activity and climate change mitigation across the nation.

Figure 9. Hikers resting on a bench at the Yokun Ridge section of the High Road. Image courtesy of BNRC, https://www.bnrc.org/reserves/the-high-road-yokun-ridge-connecting-trails.

## A. Competition & Selling Points

Berkshire County is home to a variety of trail systems, including parts of the Appalachian Trail, Ashuwillticook Rail Trail, and Mount Greylock. The High Road stands apart from the rest due to its mission to lead in-and-out of municipalities. The High Road will lead directly into Stockbridge's Main Street, where a variety of historical and modern organizations, small businesses, cafes, and restaurants are located. The High Road will increase eco-friendly tourism, while also providing recreational and conservation benefits across Berkshire County.

## B. Seriousness of Problem & Urge to Action

In recent years, Berkshire County has been facing climate change-related issues, primarily air particle pollution, temperature rises, and flooding. Each of these issues poses drastic effects on the local environment, infrastructure, and people. Air particle pollution has lowered the average

life span of Berkshire County citizens, temperature rises have caused an increase in heatstroke-related deaths and a decrease in agricultural yields, and flooding has caused damage to homes and roads. Irreversible damage will be done to the environment and citizens if preventative measures are not taken soon.

Land conservation is a proven way to mitigate the effects caused by climate change. Land conservation can help purify air, decrease temperatures, and regulate flooding. By forming accessible trails through parcels of conserved land, BNRC can ensure they are safe from deforestation and industrialization.

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## B. Image Credit

Cover Image. [Girl with Leaf Over Face] *Berkshire Natural Resources Council*, https://www.bnrc.org/. Digital Image. 12 Dec. 2025.

Figure 1. [Mahanna Cobble Reserve Trailhead] *Berkshire Natural Resources Council,* https://www.bnrc.org/story/bnrc-opens-new-mahanna-cobble-trail. Digital Image. 12 Dec. 2025.

Figure 2. [Life Expectancy in Berkshire County Based on Neighborhood] *Breathe Easy Berkshires, https://breatheeasyberkshires.org/our-mission/*. Digital Image. 12 Dec. 2025.

Figure 3. [Decadal Temperature Anomalies in New England] Young, Stephen, *MDPI,* https://www.mdpi.com/2225-1154/9/12/176. Digital Image. 12 Dec. 2025.

Figure 4. [Rain Abnormality Rates in the Northeast of the U.S.] *National Weather Service, https://www.weather.gov/car/July2021ClimateReview*. Digital Image. 12 Dec. 2025.

Figure 5. [Map of the High Road] *Berkshire Natural Resources Council,* https://www.bnrc.org/reserves/the-high-road-yokun-ridge-connecting-trails. Digital Image. 12 Dec. 2025

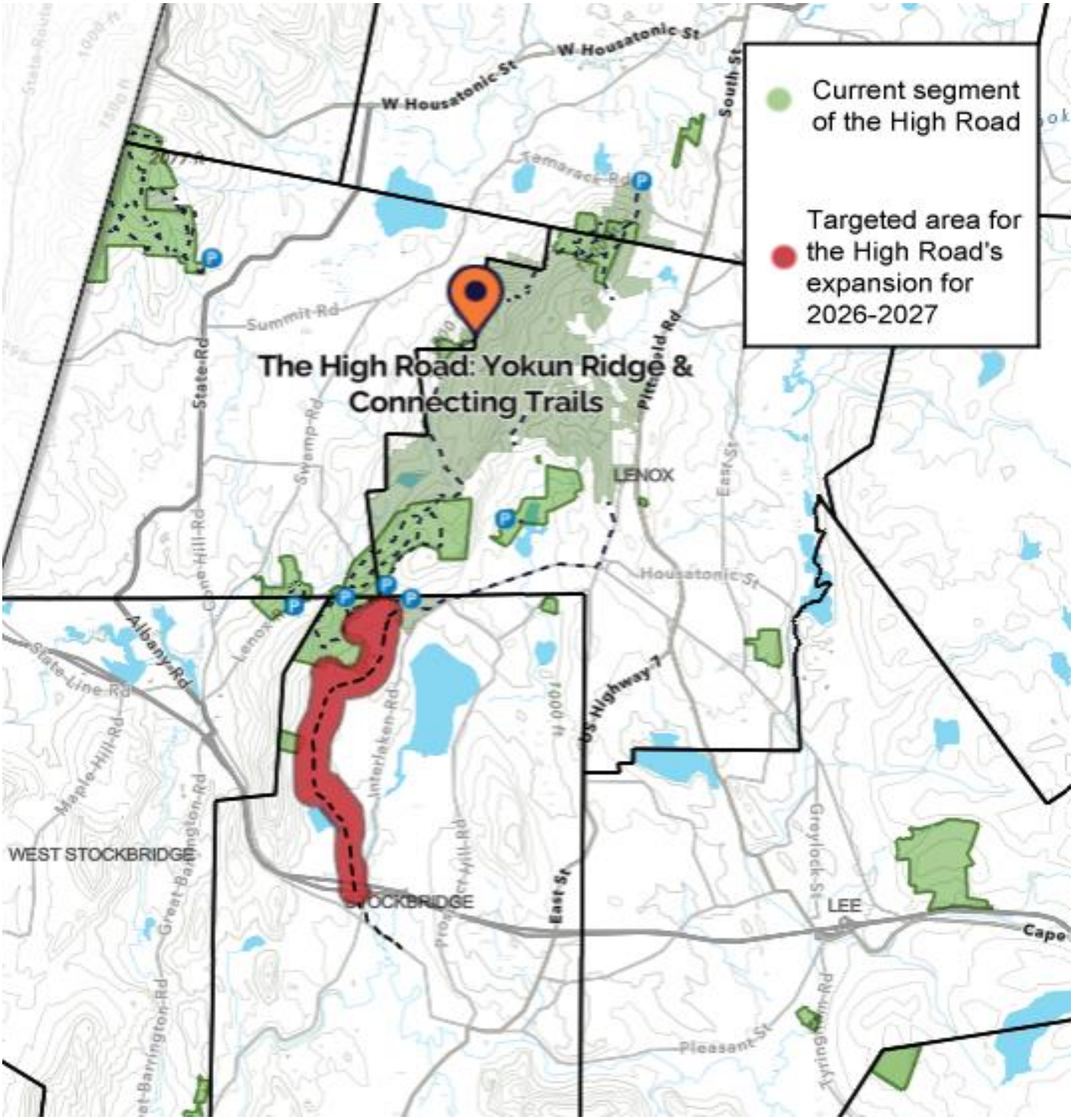
Figure 6. [Basin Pond] *Berkshire Outside*, https://berkshiresoutside.org/place/basin-pond-lee-ma/. Digital Image. 12 Dec. 2025

Figure 7. [The High Road Hikers] *Berkshire Natural Resources Council*, https://www.bnrc.org/. Digital Image. 12 Dec. 2025.

Figure 8. [Stockbridge, Main Street] *Boston.com*, https://www.boston.com/travel/new-england-travel/2024/12/06/today-show-charming-magical-main-street-in-stockbridge/. Digital Image. 12 Dec. 2025.

Figure 9. [Yokun Ridge Hikers] *Berkshire Natural Resources Council,* https://www.bnrc.org/reserves/the-high-road-yokun-ridge-connecting-trails. Digital Image. 12 Dec. 2025.

## C. Map Appendix


Current segment of the High Road
Targeted area for the High Road's expansion for 2026-2027
The High Road: Yokun Ridge & Connecting Trails
W Housatonic St
South St
Summit Rd
State Rd
Swamp Rd
Pittsfield Rd
LENOX
East St
Housatonic St
Albany Rd
State Line Rd
Maple Hill Rd
Interlaken Rd
US Highway 7
WEST STOCKBRIDGE
STOCKBRIDGE
East St
Greylock St
LEE
Cape
Pleasant St